

In this example, the folder name indicates that the Python version run from the shell is located at  
`C:\Users\Al\AppData\Local\Programs\Python\Python38\`.

## Clear the Terminal with `cls` and `clear`

Running `cls` on Windows or `clear` on macOS and Linux will clear all the text in the terminal window. This is useful if you simply want to start with a fresh-looking terminal window.

# Environment Variables and PATH

All running processes of a program, no matter the language in which it's written, have a set of variables called *environment variables* that can store a string. Environment variables often hold systemwide settings that every program would find useful. For example, the `TEMP` environment variable holds the file path where any program can store temporary files. When the operating system runs a program (such as a command line), the newly created process receives its own copy of the operating system's environment variables and values. You can change a process's environment variables independently of the operating system's set of environment variables. But those changes apply only to the process, not to the operating system or any other process.

I discuss environment variables in this chapter because one such variable, `PATH`, can help you run your programs from the command line.

## Viewing Environment Variables

You can see a list of the terminal window's environment variables by running `set` (on Windows) or `env` (on macOS and Linux) from the command line:

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```
C:\Users\Al>set
ALLUSERSPROFILE=C:\ProgramData
APPDATA=C:\Users\Al\AppData\Roaming
CommonProgramFiles=C:\Program Files\Common Files
--snip--
USERPROFILE=C:\Users\Al
```